be seen," the report explains.

It is not tomato prices alone that have been rising. Overall food and beverage inflation rose to 4.6 per cent in June, from 3.4 per cent in May. Vegetable inflation contributes significantly to overall food inflation, since they have a high weightage in food and beverage component of CPI (Consumer Price Index, a measure of retail prices of goods). Coupled with continuing high fuel prices that have made transportation charges dearer, these prices have been a considerable burden on consumers. In fact, retail inflation rose to 4.8 per cent in June, exceeding analysts' expectations, after having dipped to a 20-month low of 4.3 per cent in May following the Reserve Bank of India's staunch fight to rein in prices using its weapon of higher lending rates to commercial banks—referred to as repo rates. Continuing high inflation will delay any chances of the central bank reducing interest rates, which could make retail loans cheaper.

Historical data shows that the recent spike in tomato prices is more of a seasonal nature and is generally of the pattern seen in months such as June, September and November, in tandem with the harvesting and arrival of the vegetable, says the BoB report. Even the gap between retail and wholesale prices of tomatoes is above the long-run level, and hence some correction to the mean reverting level is expected to take place. "Our analysis suggests that the cycle of these unanticipated shocks is also short-lived (four to five months generally). Hence, with the July-November arrival of the crop, correction in prices might be seen in the second half of FY2024," it adds. Till then, however, the common man will be confined to a tomato-free diet. ■



ROHIT JAIN PARAS

RED ALERT
Sacked minister Gudha with a diary he alleged had evidence of horse-trading by the Gehlot regime, July 24

RAJASTHAN CONGRESS

AN INSIDE JOB

By Rohit Parihar

Just days after Congress leader Sachin Pilot claimed to have buried the hatchet with Rajasthan chief minister Ashok Gehlot, the circumstances surrounding his 2020 rebellion have come back to haunt the party, and that too in an election year. Stirring up the hornet's nest this time is the 55-year-old Rajendra Singh Gudha, a 'self-proclaimed' Gehlot loyalist-turned-critic, who was sacked as a minister of state on July 21. Three days later, the state assembly witnessed unruly scenes as Gudha chose that very public venue to carry out his threat to "expose" Gehlot.

The chief minister has often alleged that Pilot—the then deputy CM and Rajasthan Congress president—connived with the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) to defeat Congress candidates in the Rajya Sabha election in June 2020 and, on failing, tried to pull down his government. This very accusation has now been turned on its head with Gudha's as-yet-unsubstantiated allegations. On July 24, he reached the assembly holding a 'red diary' that he claimed belonged to Rajasthan Tourism Development Corporation chairman Dharmendra Rathore, a Gehlot loyalist. He alleged it contained details of financial transactions worth Rs 500 crore, including that of the Rajasthan government trying to buy MLAs to make them vote for Congress candidates in the Rajya Sabha polls, thus accusing the CM of political horse-trading.

As Gudha tried to table the mysterious diary during the assembly proceedings, Speaker C.P. Joshi disallowed his move. This led to a scuffle with Congress MLAs and ministers, and the eventual adjournment of the House as well as Gudha's expulsion for the remaining session—the last of the current assembly. He claims the diary got lost in the melee. Rathore, on his part,